

TITUS LIVIUS · 59 BCE - 17 CE — AB URBE CONDITA · BEGUN C. 29 BCE

— THE FOUR SURVIVING COLLECTIONS

The History of Rome

From the founding of the city to the conquest of the Mediterranean — 142 books written, 35 surviving, and the whole Roman self-image built out of them.

Livy spent forty years writing a history of Rome from its first day, and never held office, commanded a soldier or, so far as we know, left Italy. What he produced is not research in the modern sense: it is **a national epic in prose, organised year by year, whose declared purpose is to show a reader what to imitate and what to avoid**. It is also, for the first five centuries of Rome, very nearly the only continuous account we have — which is the permanent difficulty and the permanent fascination of reading it.

WRITTEN

142 books

OVER ~40 YEARS

SURVIVES

35 books

ABOUT A QUARTER

COVERED HERE

753 – 167 BCE

WITH ONE LONG GAP

IN PENGUIN

4 volumes

≈1,900 PP.

The Book, and What Is Left of It

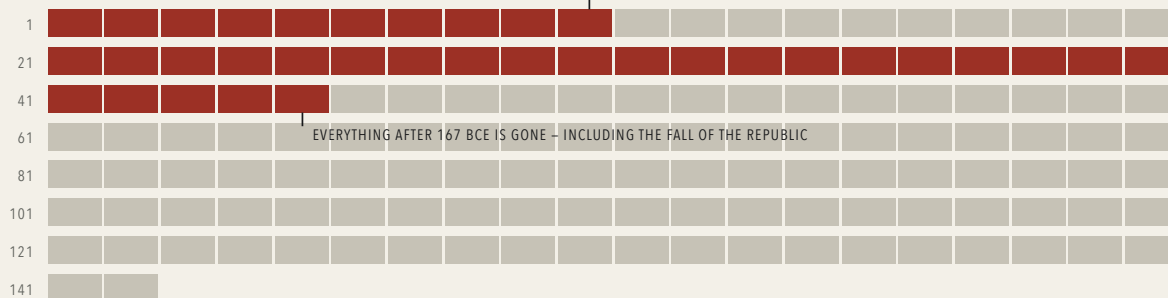
What Livy set out to do, and how much of it reached us.

Ab Urbe Condita Libri — "Books from the Founding of the City" — ran to 142 books and was published in instalments across Livy's working life, from about 29 BCE into the reign of Tiberius. It began with Aeneas and ended in 9 BCE. Roughly three-quarters of it is gone.

PLATE 01 142 BOOKS WRITTEN · 35 SURVIVING

EACH CELL IS ONE BOOK · READING LEFT TO RIGHT, TOP TO BOTTOM

BOOKS 11-20 LOST: 292-219 BCE



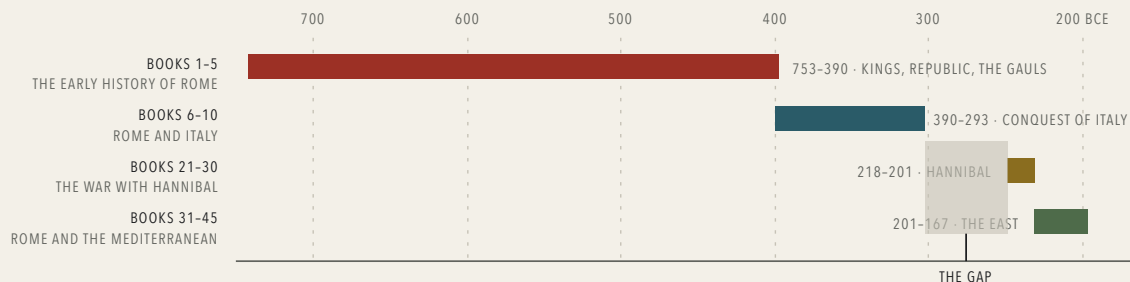
■ SURVIVES · BOOKS 1-10 AND 21-45 · ABOUT 25%

■ LOST · KNOWN ONLY FROM THE ANCIENT ONE-PARAGRAPH SUMMARIES

BOOKS 41 AND 43-45 REACH US DAMAGED, WITH PASSAGES MISSING. THE SUMMARIES (PERIOCHAE) SURVIVE FOR ALL BUT TWO BOOKS, SO WE KNOW THE SHAPE OF WHAT IS GONE.

The losses are not random in their effect. We have Rome's legendary origins and its conquest of Italy and the Mediterranean, and we have lost Livy's account of the Gracchi, Marius, Sulla, Caesar and Augustus — the part he lived closest to and the part historians would most like to read.

PLATE 02 THE FOUR VOLUMES, AND THE YEARS THEY COVER



BOOKS 11-20 COVERED 292-219 BCE AND ARE LOST: THE WAR WITH PYRRHUS, THE WHOLE FIRST PUNIC WAR, AND THE CONQUEST OF CISALPINE GAUL. THE READER OF LIVY THEREFORE JUMPS FROM THE SAMNITE WARS STRAIGHT TO HANNIBAL.

BAR LENGTH IS YEARS COVERED. NOTE HOW UNEVEN LIVY'S PACE IS: FIVE BOOKS FOR 363 YEARS, THEN TEN BOOKS FOR SEVENTEEN.

That last line is the key to reading him. Livy's scale expands as his sources thicken — the first five books average seventy years each, the Hannibal books average under two. He is not compressing for effect; he simply has almost nothing to work with at the start.

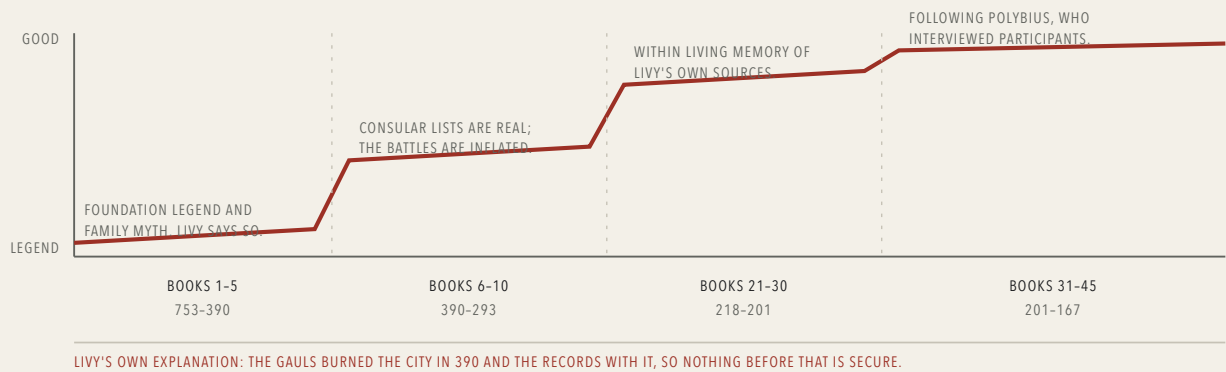
WHAT LIVY THOUGHT HE WAS DOING

The preface is short and unusually candid. Livy admits the early material is closer to poetry than to evidence, declines to argue about it, and states a purpose that is frankly moral: the reader should look at the record as at a monument, and take from it models to copy and warnings to avoid. The frame is one of decline — a hard, poor, disciplined Rome that conquered the world and was then corrupted by what it won.

"What chiefly makes the study of history wholesome and profitable is this, that you behold the lessons of every kind of experience set forth as on a conspicuous monument."

LIVY · PREFACE

PLATE 03 HOW MUCH TO TRUST, BOOK BY BOOK



A useful rule for the reader: treat Books 1-5 as what Rome believed about itself, Books 6-10 as a real skeleton with invented flesh, and Books 21-45 as history in a recognisable sense – checkable, in the last two collections, against Polybius, who was writing a generation after the events and had talked to the men involved.

THE FOUR COLLECTIONS AT A GLANCE

1-5	The Early History of Rome	Seven kings, the expulsion of the last, and a young republic that survives by inventing the tribunate, the Twelve Tables and Cincinnatus. Ends with the Gauls burning the city.
6-10	Rome and Italy	A century of grinding war against the Samnites and the Latins – and, quietly, the invention that decides everything: a graded citizenship that turns defeated enemies into manpower.
21-30	The War with Hannibal	Livy's masterpiece. Three catastrophic defeats in three years, a refusal to negotiate, and a sixteen-year recovery ending at Zama.
31-45	Rome and the Mediterranean	Macedon and the Seleucids broken in thirty years by a state that claims not to want an empire – and the money coming home starts to worry people at home.

The Early History of Rome

From Aeneas and the founding to the Gallic sack — the whole of Rome's legendary and half-legendary past.

YEARS

753 – 390 BCE

STATUS

Largely legend

THEME

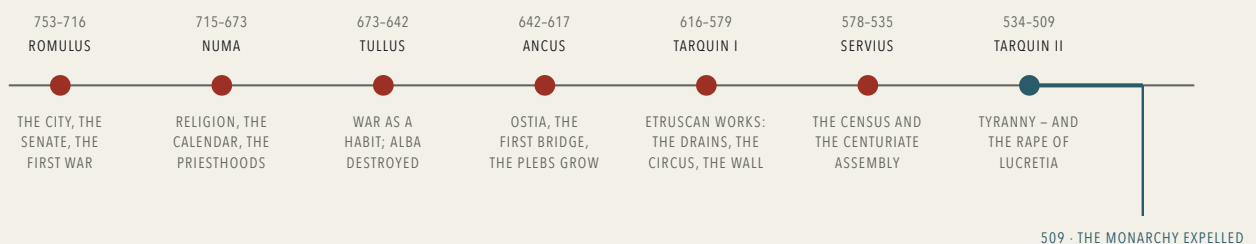
Where the virtues came from

ENDS

The city in ashes

These are the most famous and least reliable pages Livy wrote, and he knows it. The material is family tradition, priestly record, Greek speculation and patriotic invention, and out of it he assembles the founding stories every educated Roman afterwards had by heart: Romulus and Remus, the Sabine women, Horatius at the bridge, Mucius Scaevola's hand in the fire, Cincinnatus at the plough, the geese of the Capitol. **Read as evidence they are nearly worthless; read as a portrait of what Rome wanted to be, they are the most valuable thing in the book.**

PLATE 04 THE SEVEN KINGS, AND WHAT EACH IS CREDITED WITH



SEVEN KINGS FOR 244 YEARS IS AN AVERAGE REIGN OF 35 YEARS, WHICH NO DYNASTY HAS EVER MANAGED. THE LIST IS A LATER RECONSTRUCTION: REAL NAMES, PROBABLY, ATTACHED TO A MADE-UP CHRONOLOGY AND A TIDY DIVISION OF INSTITUTIONAL CREDIT.

Note the shape of the scheme: a founder, a lawgiver-priest, a warrior, a builder, two Etruscans who supply the engineering, and a tyrant whose crime justifies the Republic. It is a constitutional argument told as biography – every Roman institution gets a father, and the monarchy gets a reason to end.

The Republic Learns to Argue

With the kings gone, Livy's subject becomes a two-hundred-year quarrel between patricians and plebeians that never quite becomes a revolution. The plebs' weapon is not violence but *secession*: they walk out of the city and refuse to serve in the army, and since Rome is always at war, they are always needed back. Each walkout ends in a concession, and the concessions accumulate into a constitution.

PLATE 05 THE STRUGGLE OF THE ORDERS AS A RATCHET

TWO CENTURIES OF CONCESSIONS, NONE OF THEM REVERSED

LIVY'S OWN EXPLANATION IS MENENIUS AGRIPPA'S FABLE OF THE BELLY AND THE LIMBS: THE ORDERS NEED EACH OTHER.



The last three steps happen in Books 6–10 and the first three here, but the mechanism is one thing and it is worth seeing whole. Livy's patrician sympathies are visible throughout – he dislikes demagogues and admires senatorial restraint – yet the story he tells is one of steady plebeian victory.

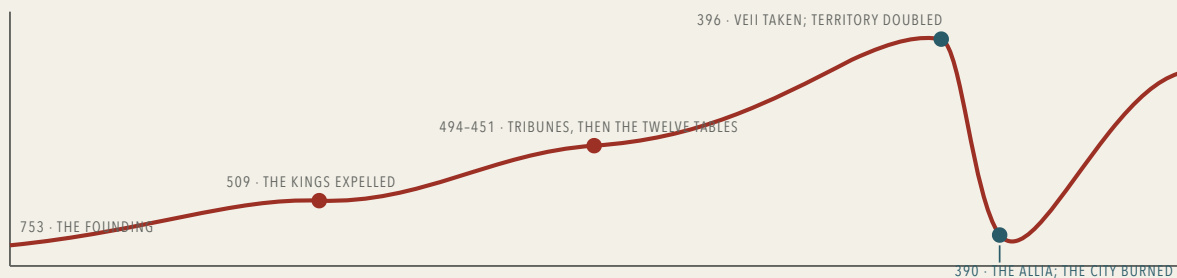
Bk 5 Veii, and Then the Gauls THE MORAL SET-PIECES, AND WHAT THEY ARE FOR

406 – 390 BCE

Horatius holding the bridge alone; Mucius Scaevola burning off his own right hand to show Porsenna what Romans are; Cincinnatus taking the dictatorship, winning in sixteen days and returning to his four acres; Verginius killing his own daughter rather than let a magistrate take her. Each is almost certainly invented. Each dramatises one virtue – *constantia*, *fortitudo*, *modestia*, *pudicitia* – and each was told to Roman schoolboys for the next five hundred years. Livy is manufacturing a civic character, and he says in the preface that this is the point of history. Within five years a Gallic army destroys the Roman force at the Allia and burns the city; only the Capitol holds, saved by the sacred geese. Camillus is recalled, drives the Gauls out, and talks the Romans out of abandoning the ruins for Veii.

PLATE 06 THE ARC OF BOOKS 1–5

LIVY'S DESIGN: THE HIGHEST POINT AND THE LOWEST ARE FIVE YEARS APART



CAMILLUS IS RECALLED, DRIVES THE GAULS OUT, AND TALKS THE ROMANS OUT OF ABANDONING THE RUINS FOR VEII.
THE LESSON LIVY DRAWS IS RELIGIOUS AS MUCH AS POLITICAL: ROME FALLS WHEN IT NEGLECTS THE AUSPICES.

The sack of 390 is Livy's explanation for why nothing before it can be verified: the records burned. It is also his hinge. Everything after is a recovery narrative, and the Rome that rebuilds is the one that will take Italy in the next collection.

Brennus threw his sword onto the scale with the gold and said the word Livy makes famous: *vae victis* — woe to the conquered. Rome spent the next three centuries making sure the phrase was said by Romans.

BOOK 5 · THE GALLIC RANSOM

Rome and Italy

From the rebuilding after the Gauls to the end of the Third Samnite War — the century in which a city becomes the master of a peninsula.

YEARS

390 – 293 BCE

STATUS

A real skeleton

THEME

Manpower, not genius

LEAST READ

and the most instructive

This is the collection people skip, and it contains the answer to the question the other three raise: how did Rome absorb defeats that would have finished any other state? The answer is worked out here, in a hundred years of unglamorous fighting against the Samnites — a confederation of hill peoples who beat Rome repeatedly and still lost, because Rome had found a way to turn conquered enemies into soldiers.

PLATE 07 THE INSTRUMENT: CITIZENSHIP IN GRADES

STATUS	WHAT YOU GET	WHAT YOU OWE	TYPICALLY
FULL CITIZEN	VOTE, OFFICE, FULL PROTECTION OF LAW	LEGIONARY SERVICE; TAX	OLD ROMAN LAND
CITIZEN SINE SUFFRAGIO	LAW AND TRADE, BUT NO VOTE	LEGIONARY SERVICE; TAX	NEARBY TOWNS
LATIN RIGHT	TRADE, INTERMARRIAGE, MIGRATION – AND FULL CITIZENSHIP IF YOU MOVE TO ROME	TROOPS ON DEMAND	LATIN COLONIES
ALLIED COMMUNITY	LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT; NO TRIBUTE	TROOPS ON DEMAND	EVERYONE ELSE

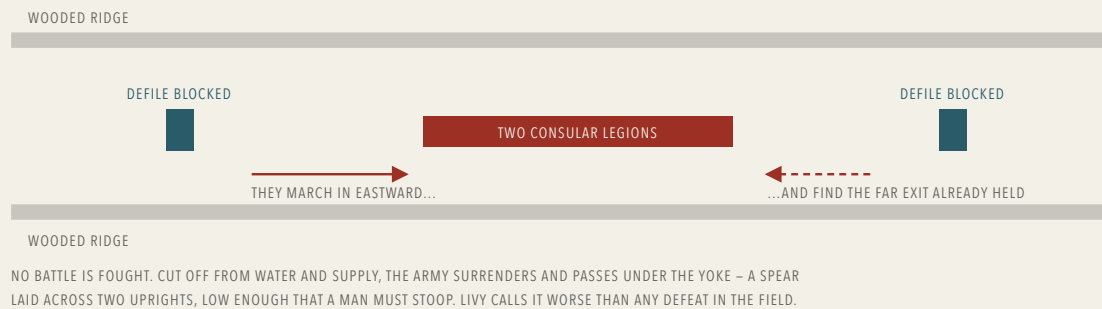
WHY IT DECIDES EVERYTHING

A DEFEATED CITY IS NOT ENSLAVED OR GARRISONED; IT IS ENROLLED. IT KEEPS ITS OWN GOVERNMENT, PAYS NO TRIBUTE, AND SUPPLIES SOLDIERS. ROME'S ARMY THEREFORE GROWS WITH EVERY WAR IT WINS – AND CAN SURVIVE LOSING SEVERAL.

Livy never presents this as a policy; it accumulates settlement by settlement, most decisively after the Latin War of 340–338. But it is the reason Hannibal could destroy three Roman armies and still not win: he was fighting a manpower pool of perhaps 700,000, and he could not detach enough of it.

Three wars over fifty years, fought in mountains that suited the enemy, and Livy does not hide that Rome lost a great many of the engagements. The central episode is the disaster at the **Caudine Forks** in 321, where an entire consular army marched into a blind valley, was trapped without a battle, and was released only after passing under the yoke — a ritual humiliation Livy describes at length and with real pain.

PLATE 08 THE CAUDINE FORKS, 321 BCE



Rome's response is the pattern of the whole collection: repudiate the treaty on a technicality, hand the officers who swore it back to the Samnites, and resume the war. Livy is uncomfortable with the legal manoeuvre and reports it anyway – one of the places his honesty gets the better of his patriotism.

PLATE 09 PHALANX TO MANIPLE – THE REFORM THESE WARS FORCE

THE PHALANX – ONE BLOCK



IRRESISTIBLE ON FLAT GROUND, STRAIGHT AHEAD.
ON BROKEN GROUND THE LINE OPENS GAPS,
AND A GAP IN A PHALANX IS FATAL.



SAMNITE COUNTRY IS ALL BROKEN GROUND.

LIVY CREDITS THE CHANGE TO THE SAMNITE WARS THEMSELVES. IT IS THE SINGLE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL THING IN BOOKS 6–10, AND HE GIVES IT A PARAGRAPH.

THE MANIPULAR LEGION – THIRTY BLOCKS



EACH BLOCK MANOEUVRES ON ITS OWN AND FITS
THE GROUND. THE GAPS ARE DELIBERATE: A TIRED
FRONT LINE FALLS BACK THROUGH THEM AND A
FRESH LINE STEPS FORWARD.

THREE CHANCES TO WIN THE SAME BATTLE –
AND AN ARMY THAT CAN LOSE ITS FRONT AND HOLD.

The reform is also social: the three lines are age and wealth classes, so the legion encodes the census. When Rome later meets the Macedonian phalanx in Books 31–45, this is the argument that gets settled – and Livy, writing much later, knows the answer in advance.

The collection closes at Sentinum in 295, where Rome faced a coalition of Samnites, Etruscans, Umbrians and Gauls and won the largest battle fought in Italy to that date. Livy gives it the full set-piece treatment, including the second *devotio* of a Decius Mus — a consul formally dedicating himself and the enemy to the gods of the underworld and riding into their line to die. Three years later the Samnites make peace, and Italy south of the Po is Rome's.

The War with Hannibal

The Second Punic War, from the siege of Saguntum to the peace after Zama — ten books on seventeen years.

YEARS

218 – 201 BCE

STATUS

Checkable against Polybius

THEME

Refusing to lose

REPUTATION

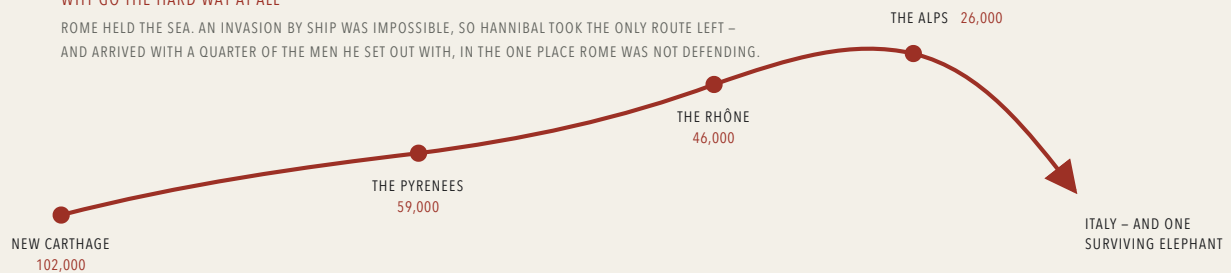
Livy's masterpiece

This is the collection that made Livy's name and still justifies it. The narrative pace slows to roughly two years a book, the sources are good, and the material is the best story in ancient history: a Carthaginian general crosses the Alps with an army and elephants, destroys three Roman armies in three years — the third in the worst single day any European army has suffered — and then cannot finish the job, because **Rome's answer to catastrophe is to raise another army and decline to discuss terms.**

PLATE 10 HANNIBAL'S MARCH, AND THE IDEA BEHIND IT

WHY GO THE HARD WAY AT ALL

ROME HELD THE SEA. AN INVASION BY SHIP WAS IMPOSSIBLE, SO HANNIBAL TOOK THE ONLY ROUTE LEFT – AND ARRIVED WITH A QUARTER OF THE MEN HE SET OUT WITH, IN THE ONE PLACE ROME WAS NOT DEFENDING.



THE STRATEGY, AND WHY IT FAILED

HANNIBAL COULD NOT BESIEGE ROME AND NEVER TRIED SERIOUSLY. HIS PLAN WAS POLITICAL: WIN BATTLES SO VISIBLY THAT ROME'S ITALIAN ALLIES WOULD DEFECT, AND THE CONFEDERATION WOULD COME APART. SOME DID. MOST DID NOT – AND THAT, RATHER THAN ANY BATTLE, IS THE REASON HE LOST.

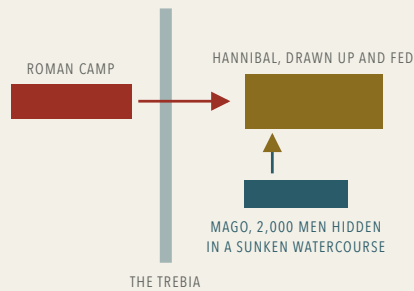
Livy's numbers here come from a monument Hannibal himself set up in southern Italy, reported by Polybius. They are among the most trustworthy figures in the ancient record, and they show the price of the route: he lost more men to mountains and desertion than the Romans took from him in any battle.

Hannibal's first three victories are three different tricks, and Livy narrates each as a lesson in how a Roman commander gets himself killed. At the **Trebia** he provokes a crossing of an icy river at dawn by hungry men, then springs a force hidden in a watercourse. At **Trasimene** he sets the largest ambush in recorded history along a lake shore in morning fog. At **Cannae** he does something harder: he wins a straight fight, in the open, outnumbered nearly two to one.

PLATE 11 TREBIA AND TRASIMENE · THE TWO AMBUSHES

TREBIA · DECEMBER 218

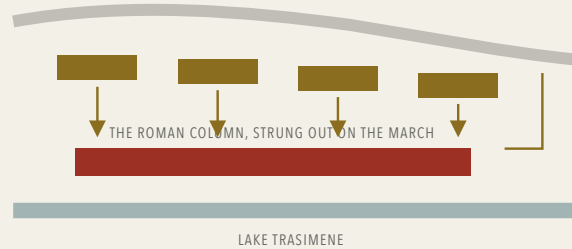
BAIT, A COLD RIVER, AND A FORCE IN THE STREAMBED



THE ROMANS CROSS AT DAWN, WET AND UNFED, AND ARE HIT FROM BEHIND. PERHAPS 10,000 OF 40,000 CUT THEIR WAY OUT.

TRASIMENE · JUNE 217

A ROAD BETWEEN HILLS AND WATER, IN FOG
WOODED HILLS



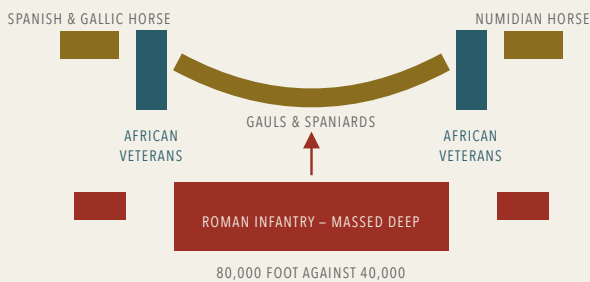
THE TRAP CLOSES AT BOTH ENDS. THERE IS NO ROOM TO DEPLOY AND NOWHERE TO RUN BUT THE LAKE. ABOUT 15,000 DIE, INCLUDING THE CONSUL FLAMINIUS. ROME APPOINTS A DICTATOR THE SAME MONTH.

Both battles turn on the same Roman weakness – a consul with a one-year command, needing a victory before his term ends, facing a general with no such deadline. Livy makes the institutional point himself, through the mouths of the senators who argue for Fabius.

PLATE 12 CANNAE, 2 AUGUST 216 · THE DOUBLE ENVELOPMENT

1 · CONTACT

HANNIBAL BOWS HIS WEAKEST TROOPS FORWARD



THE MECHANISM

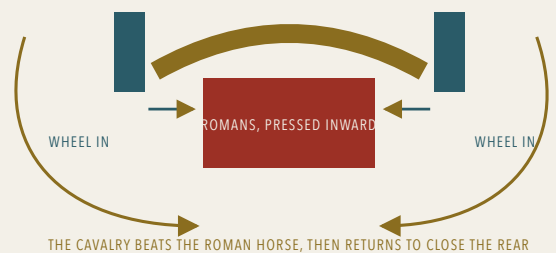
A DELIBERATELY WEAK CENTRE THAT RETREATS ON PURPOSE WITHOUT BREAKING. HANNIBAL STOOD IN IT HIMSELF TO MAKE SURE IT BENT AND DID NOT SNAP.

THE COST

LIVY: 47,700 ROMAN DEAD. POLYBIUS: ABOUT 70,000. ONE CONSUL, 80 SENATORS, AND PERHAPS A FIFTH OF ROME'S AVAILABLE MANPOWER, IN ONE DAY.

2 · THE POCKET

THE CENTRE GIVES GROUND; THE WINGS DO NOT



ENCIRCLED, THE ROMAN MASS CANNOT USE ITS NUMBERS: ONLY THE OUTER RANKS CAN FIGHT, AND THE POCKET IS KILLED FROM OUTSIDE IN.

WHY IT IS STILL TAUGHT

IT IS THE MODEL CASE OF DESTROYING A LARGER FORCE BY ENVELOPMENT – STUDIED BY NAPOLEON, AND CONSCIOUSLY IMITATED BY SCIPIO AT ZAMA FOURTEEN YEARS LATER, AGAINST HANNIBAL.

The two casualty figures are worth pausing on. Livy and Polybius are our two sources, they used overlapping material, and they differ by nearly fifty per cent on the largest battle of the war. This is the normal condition of ancient numbers, and a useful calibration for every other figure in the book.

WHAT ROME DID NEXT

Refused to ransom the survivors. Forbade the word "peace" to be spoken in public. Enrolled slaves, debtors and boys under seventeen. Reduced the property qualification for service. And formally thanked the defeated consul Varro, in Livy's most quoted sentence of the war, "because he had not despaired of the republic." Hannibal won the battle in an afternoon and then discovered he had no way to convert it into a victory.

PLATE 13 THREE ROMAN STRATEGIES, TRIED IN ORDER**SEEK BATTLE**

SEMPRONIUS, FLAMINIUS, VARRO

MEET HIM IN THE FIELD WITH
SUPERIOR NUMBERS AND WIN.IT IS WHAT CONSULS ARE FOR,
AND THEIR YEAR IS SHORT.RESULT: TREBIA, TRASIMENE,
CANNAE. THREE ARMIES GONE
IN UNDER THREE YEARS.**REFUSE BATTLE**

FABIUS MAXIMUS, DICTATOR 217

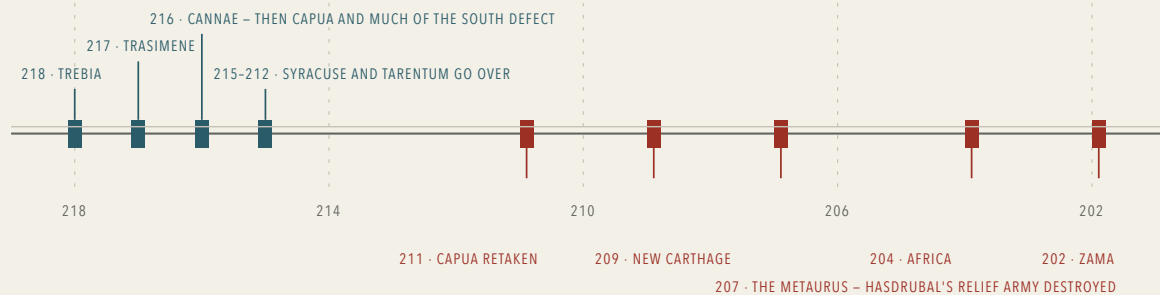
SHADOW HIM. TAKE THE HIGH
GROUND. BURN THE FORAGE.NEVER ACCEPT A BATTLE HE
HAS CHOSEN THE GROUND FOR.RESULT: IT WORKS, AND IT IS
HATED. HE IS NICKNAMED
CUNCTATOR – THE DELAYER.**CHANGE THE BOARD**

SCIPIO, FROM 210

IGNORE HANNIBAL IN ITALY.
TAKE SPAIN, HIS RECRUITINGGROUND AND SILVER SUPPLY.
THEN INVADE AFRICA AND MAKE
CARTHAGE RECALL HIM.RESULT: NEW CARTHAGE 209,
ILIPA 206, AFRICA 204,
AND ZAMA 202.

LIVY IS FAIR TO ALL THREE AND CLEARLY PREFERS THE SECOND. THE FABIAN CHAPTERS ARE WHERE HIS OWN POLITICAL TEMPER SHOWS MOST PLAINLY.

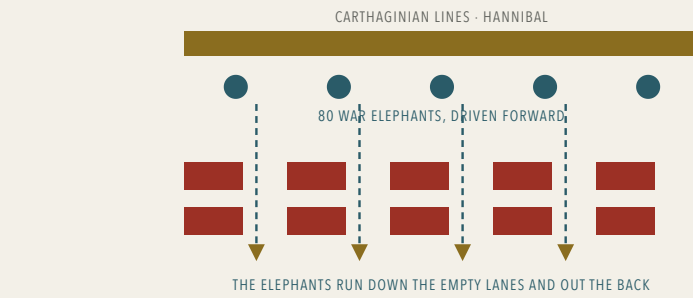
The sequence matters: Fabius buys the time in which Rome can afford to grow a Scipio. Livy's Senate learns slowly and expensively, but it does learn, and it keeps commanders in post for years once it has found good ones – quietly abandoning the annual command that had cost it three armies.

PLATE 14 THE WAR, YEAR BY YEAR**HANNIBAL REMAINS UNDEFEATED IN ITALY FOR FIFTEEN YEARS – AND STEADILY LOSES THE WAR**

THE METAURUS IN 207 IS THE TURN LIVY MARKS HARDEST: HANNIBAL LEARNS OF HIS BROTHER'S DEFEAT WHEN THE HEAD IS THROWN INTO HIS CAMP.

The visual point is the asymmetry. Every Carthaginian success is a battle; every Roman success is a place taken and held. Hannibal wins the encounters and loses the map, because Rome can replace an army and he cannot.

THE ELEPHANT PROBLEM, SOLVED



SCIPIO LINES HIS MANIPLES UP IN COLUMNS RATHER THAN STAGGERING THEM, LEAVING STRAIGHT CORRIDORS. TRUMPETS AND JAVELINS DO THE REST.
A CHARGE DESIGNED TO BREAK A SOLID LINE MEETS A LINE WITH HOLES IN IT.

AND THEN THE CANNÆ MANOEUVRE



THE CAVALRY DRIVES OFF THE CARTHAGINIAN HORSE, THEN RETURNS AND HITS THE REAR OF HANNIBAL'S INFANTRY. IT IS EXACTLY WHAT WAS DONE TO THE ROMANS AT CANNÆ, PERFORMED AGAINST ITS INVENTOR.

THE DECISIVE CHANGE WAS DIPLOMATIC, NOT TACTICAL: ROME HAD TAKEN NUMIDIA'S CAVALRY AWAY FROM CARTHAGE.

Livy gives Hannibal a dignified exit – an interview with Scipio before the battle, and afterwards the advice to Carthage to accept the terms. The peace strips Carthage of its fleet, its Spanish empire and its freedom to make war. It is not destroyed; that waits fifty years, in books we no longer have.

Rome and the Mediterranean

From the peace with Carthage to the destruction of the Macedonian kingdom — the thirty-four years in which Rome becomes the only power that matters.

YEARS

201 – 167 BCE

STATUS

Following Polybius closely

THEME

Empire acquired reluctantly

ENDS

Pydna, and the money coming home

Rome finishes the Hannibalic war exhausted and immediately declares another, on Philip V of Macedon. Within thirty-four years it has broken Macedon twice, humbled the Seleucid empire, dismantled both, and annexed almost none of it. Livy's account — largely Polybius, translated and reshaped — is the best surviving narrative of how the Mediterranean acquired a single master, and of how uneasy that master was about saying so.

PLATE 16 THE BOARD IN 200 BCE

POWER	STRENGTH	WEAKNESS	BY 167 BCE
ROME	MANPOWER; ALLIED LEVIES	EXHAUSTED; DEEP IN DEBT	THE ONLY POWER LEFT
MACEDON	THE PHALANX; A WAR CHEST	SMALL POPULATION; HATED IN GREECE	ABOLISHED; SPLIT INTO FOUR
SELEUCIDS	VAST TERRITORY; ANTIOCHUS III	CANNOT HOLD WHAT IT CLAIMS	BEATEN AT MAGNESIA; CONFINED
PTOLEMAIC EGYPT	GRAIN, GOLD, ALEXANDRIA	A CHILD KING AND A REGENCY	A ROMAN CLIENT
GREEK LEAGUES	WEALTH; NAVAL BASES	NEVER UNITED FOR LONG	"FREE" – AND SUPERVISED

LIVY'S OWN FRAMING, TAKEN FROM POLYBIUS: THE ASTONISHING THING IS NOT THAT ROME WON BUT THAT IT DID SO IN FIFTY-THREE YEARS, AND THAT A STATE WITH NO NAVY WORTH THE NAME IN 264 HAD, BY 167, NO RIVAL ON ANY COAST OF THE SEA.

Polybius wrote his history to explain exactly this, for a Greek readership that needed to understand what had happened to them. Livy inherits the analysis and adds a Roman conscience to it – which is why these books keep circling back to whether the conquest was good for Rome.

The Second Macedonian War is decided at **Cynoscephalae** in 197, on a ridge in fog, when the two armies collide before either has deployed. Half the Macedonian phalanx forms up and is unstoppable; the other half is caught still marching. A Roman tribune takes twenty maniples out of the winning line, turns them round, and hits the successful phalanx from behind. It is the moment the ancient world's decisive weapon stops being decisive, and Livy — following Polybius — explains why at length.

PLATE 17 WHY THE LEGION BEATS THE PHALANX

THE PHALANX		THE LEGION
THE SARISSA – A PIKE 5 TO 7 METRES LONG	WEAPON	TWO JAVELINS, THEN A SHORT STABBING SWORD
FIVE PIKE-POINTS PROJECT AHEAD OF EACH MAN	FRONT	NOTHING PROJECTS; THE FIGHT IS AT ARM'S LENGTH
THE WHOLE LINE IS ONE BODY	UNIT	THIRTY MANIPLES, EACH ACTING ALONE
NEEDS A FLAT, UNBROKEN PLAIN	GROUND	FIGHTS ON ANYTHING; PREFERS BROKEN GROUND
A GAP CANNOT BE CLOSED; THE FLANK IS NAKED	DISORDER	GAPS ARE THE DESIGN – MEN STEP THROUGH THEM
NONE – EVERYTHING IS IN THE LINE	RESERVE	TWO FULL LINES BEHIND THE FIRST

LIVY'S VERDICT, AFTER CYNOSCEPHALAE AND AGAIN AFTER PYDNA: HEAD-ON THE PHALANX WINS, AND IT IS ALMOST NEVER ALLOWED TO FIGHT HEAD-ON.

This is the argument Livy already rehearsed in Book 9, in a famous digression asking what would have happened had Alexander turned west. The answer he gives there is patriotic and the answer he gives here is evidentiary – and by 168 they agree.

In 196, at the Isthmian Games at Corinth, Flamininus has a herald proclaim the Greek cities free — no garrisons, no tribute, no governor. Livy records the crowd's disbelief and the birds falling out of the air at the noise. Two years later Rome is at war with **Antiochus III**, who has come into Greece at the invitation of the Aetolians on the grounds that Rome's freedom is a fraud. He is thrown out of Thermopylae in 191 and broken at **Magnesia** in 190, and the peace of Apamea in 188 confines the Seleucid empire behind the Taurus and imposes an indemnity so large it takes a generation to pay.

PLATE 18 THE METHOD: WIN, WITHDRAW, RETURN



WHETHER THE RELUCTANCE WAS SINCERE OR A CHEAPER FORM OF CONTROL IS THE OLDEST ARGUMENT IN ROMAN

Bks 39–45 **Pydna, and the Anxiety at Home** THAT COMPLICATE IT.

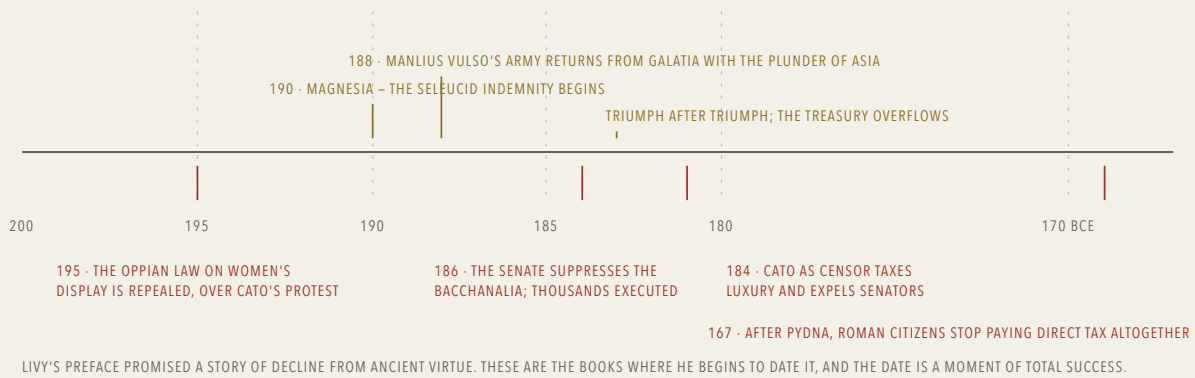
188 – 167 BCE

The last books run two stories in parallel. Abroad, the Third Macedonian War ends at **Pydna** in 168, where Perseus's phalanx advances irresistibly across a plain until the ground breaks up beneath it, gaps open, and Aemilius Paullus feeds maniples into them. Livy says Paullus later admitted he had never seen anything so terrifying as that phalanx coming on. The battle lasts about an hour.

At home, the mood is anything but triumphant. Livy's Roman reader in the age of Augustus is meant to notice that this is precisely when the wealth starts arriving, and precisely when the complaints about luxury, foreign religion and the decay of the old discipline begin.

PLATE 19 WHAT CAME HOME, AND THE REACTION TO IT

THE CONQUEST PAYS FOR ITSELF – AND THE ROMANS START WORRYING ABOUT WHAT IT IS DOING TO THEM



The Bacchanalian affair of 186 is the strangest episode in the collection and the most revealing: a secretive cult is suppressed by senatorial decree across all Italy, with thousands put to death. Livy tells it as a story about moral contagion from the east. It reads today as a state discovering it can police belief.

Book 45 ends in 167, with Aemilius Paullus's triumph, the Macedonian royal treasure carried through the streets, and Perseus walking behind the chariot. Everything Livy wrote about the next century and a half is lost.

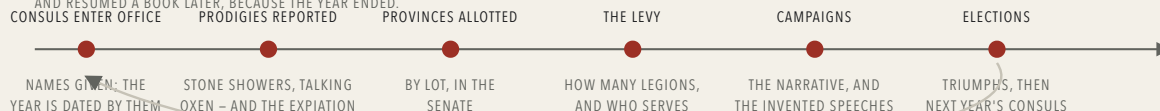
WHERE THE SURVIVING TEXT STOPS

How to Read Him *What Livy does that a modern historian would not, and why he does it.*

PLATE 20 THE ANNALISTIC YEAR – LIVY'S REPEATING UNIT

THE FORM IS A MAGISTRATE'S CALENDAR, NOT A STORY

IT IS INHERITED FROM THE PRIESTLY YEAR-TABLETS, AND IT EXPLAINS LIVY'S ODDDEST HABIT: A CAMPAIGN IN SPAIN IS CUT OFF IN SEPTEMBER AND RESUMED A BOOK LATER, BECAUSE THE YEAR ENDED.



Understanding the annalistic frame removes most of the frustration of reading Livy straight through. The prodigy lists in particular are not superstition intruding on history; they are a formal part of the year's public record, like the census, and he includes them because the record did.

01 The speeches are composed, not reported

Nobody transcribed Camillus. The speeches follow the Greek historiographical convention: the author writes what the situation demanded, to reveal character and lay out the arguments on both sides. They are the most artful thing in Livy and the least evidentiary. Read them as an essayist's dramatisation of a decision.

02 The numbers inflate, especially early

Livy inherited annalists – Valerius Antias above all – who multiplied enemy dead freely, and he sometimes says so, reporting two figures and declining to choose. Where Polybius survives alongside him, the two differ by up to fifty per cent. Treat every casualty and army figure as an order of magnitude.

03 He is not a researcher

He worked from earlier literary histories rather than from archives, does not appear to have consulted the linen rolls or the priestly records directly, and never visited a battlefield he describes. His originality is in shaping and in prose, not in discovery. Tacitus, a working senator, is a different kind of writer entirely.

04 The moral frame does real work

The thesis – that Rome rose through discipline and poverty and is being destroyed by the wealth of its conquests – shapes what gets emphasis. Foreign luxury is always suspect; popular leaders are usually demagogues; the Senate is usually right. Knowing the bias makes the narrative more useful, not less.

05 And yet he reports against himself

He records the Caudine Forks repudiation, the massacre at New Carthage, the cynicism of the Greek settlement and the brutality in Epirus. Where his sources disagree he often says so. He is a partisan witness who does not suppress inconvenient testimony – which is precisely why he remains usable.

A PRACTICAL READING ORDER

- **Start with *The War with Hannibal*** (Books 21–30). It is the best written, the most reliable, and it needs no prior context.
- **Then *The Early History of Rome*** (Books 1–5) for the legends, read as national myth rather than as record. Book 5 is the finest single book Livy wrote.
- ***Rome and the Mediterranean*** (Books 31–45) next, if the Hellenistic world interests you — it is Polybius with a Roman conscience attached.
- ***Rome and Italy*** (Books 6–10) last. It is the hardest going and contains the structural answer to why any of the rest happened.
- **Read alongside:** Polybius, Books 1–6, for the same events from the Greek side and for the constitutional analysis Livy never attempts.

01 **Rome's advantage was institutional, not military.**

It lost
battles
constantly.
What
no rival
could
match
was a
citizenship
that
turned
defeated
enemies
into
future
soldiers,
and a
Senate
that
could
raise
another
army
after
losing
50,000
men in
a day.

02 **The annual magistracy was a weapon and a wound.**

It
prevented
tyranny
for four
centuries
and
handed
Hannibal
three
victories.
The war
against
him is
where
Rome
quietly
learns
to keep
good
commanders
in post
– and
where
the road
to the
Caesars
begins.

03 **Livy's early books are evidence about Livy's Rome, not early Rome.**

They tell
you
what
the
Augustan
age
believed
about
its
ancestors,
which is
a real
historical
fact
about a
real
period
– just
not the
period
being
described.

04 **The moral decline thesis has a date in the text.**

Livy
locates
the turn
in the
180s, at
the
moment
of
maximum
success,
when
eastern
money
arrives.
Whether
or not
the
analysis
holds, it
is the
same
argument
Sallust,
Cato
and
later
Gibbon
all
make.

05 **Empire arrived before anyone admitted wanting it.**

Rome
declared
Greece
free in
196
and
abolished
Macedon
in 167.
Livy
shows
the
whole
sequence
without
ever
quite
resolving
whether
the
reluctance
was
genuine.

Machiavelli's

Discourses

is a

commentary

on the

first ten

books.

For

fifteen

hundred

years,

"Roman

virtue"

meant

the

specific

stories

in this

specific

text –

which is

a great

deal of

influence

for a

writer

who

never

checked

an

archive.

COLOPHON

Livy · The History of Rome

A reader's summary of the thirty-five surviving books of *Ab Urbe Condita*, as published in four Penguin Classics volumes. Every plate was drawn for this document. Battle schematics are diagrams of the tactical idea, not maps: positions are indicative and not to scale. Where ancient sources disagree on numbers, both figures are given.

COLLECTIONS SUMMARISED

Books 1–5 · The Early History of Rome
Books 6–10 · Rome and Italy
Books 21–30 · The War with Hannibal
Books 31–45 · Rome and the
Mediterranean

PLATES

20 hand-drawn figures
All vector; all legible at print size

COMPANION

Durant · The Story of Civilization I–IV
in a second document

READ ALONGSIDE

Polybius · The Histories
Machiavelli · Discourses on Livy